



State Stability and International Conflict Management

Fall 2025

Class meeting time and location: Wed, 9:00PM-5:00PM, SWNG 108

Instructor:

Dr. Sally Sharif

Office Hours: Mon 2:00PM-4:00PM

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Course Description

Violent conflict is a complicated political process. It often involves multiple parties with competing objectives that act strategically and are supported by diverse constituencies or international actors. This makes analyzing conflict and its termination challenging. This course starts with a critical examination of state fragility and the conflict trap, exploring the intricate processes that lead to destabilization and recurrence of conflict. Students will delve into various aspects of state stability, including the conceptualization and operationalization of state fragility, the factors that contribute to a well-functioning state, and the mechanisms behind the recurrence of civil wars. The course then transitions to scrutinizing strategies for conflict prevention and management, with a focus on different forms of conflict management, including disarmament, demobilization, reintegration, and peace agreement implementation.

A pivotal part of this course is the emphasis on designing and understanding causal mechanisms that lead to conflict recurrence or the failure of international peacebuilding efforts. Through critical engagement with contemporary research, case studies, and theoretical frameworks, students will develop the ability to construct and analyze causal models that explain the dynamics of conflict processes. This analytical approach is crucial for comprehending the complexities of conflict and the challenges inherent in international interventions aimed at building and sustaining peace. By dissecting these causal relationships, students will gain a deeper insight into not only why conflicts recur or peace efforts falter but also how such outcomes can be effectively addressed or prevented.

Course Learning Objectives

This course has 5 core learning objectives. Students will be able to:

1. **Conceptualize and operationalize ideas:** Students will describe the conceptualization and operationalization of ideas, such as state fragility and state-building, drawing insights from seminal works and critically evaluating the theoretical underpinnings of existing approaches.
2. **Build causal arguments:** Students will learn to build causal arguments, identifying antecedent conditions, causa and outcome variables, and mechanisms.

3. **Evaluate arguments:** Students will differentiate and critically evaluate the relative strengths and limitations of leading approaches to understanding conflict and conflict management.
4. **Evaluate Strategies:** Engaging with disarmament, demobilization, reintegration, security sector reform, and peace agreement implementation, students will develop the ability to critically evaluate and analyze different conflict management strategies, addressing challenges and puzzles associated with interventions.
5. **Develop a research question:** Students will investigate an idea directly related to the course material and write a research paper.
6. **Present an idea:** Students will present an executive summary of the research paper and take questions from a critical audience.

Course Assignments, Due Dates and Grading

Weekly tests (30%)

This course tests knowledge of the readings and attention to the lecture through weekly multiple-choice tests during the lecture via Canvas. Students should have access to a computer or phone during class to do the test.

Discussion lead (10%):

Students will co-lead one seminar discussion. Precise order TBD collectively on Week 1.

An effective discussion leader will typically:

1. Provide opening remarks that set the agenda for the discussion
2. Identify, briefly, the themes that in their view cut across the articles and propose a coherent plan to discuss them
3. Create an inviting space such that all students have an opportunity to share their insights, ask questions, and puzzle through difficult concepts or arguments
4. Manage the discussion such that participation is balanced among students
5. Listen attentively throughout the discussion to be able to synthesize areas of agreement and disagreement among the group at the conclusion of the seminar
6. Close out the discussion by synthesizing major takeaways

Active class participation (10%):

As this is a seminar course, students will be evaluated on their participation in each class. Attendance in each class is a necessary step to earn participation points. Students will be most prepared to participate in the class discussions by completing the assigned readings in advance and with a critical eye: What is the main point author is making? How does this reading compare to other literature exploring the same topic? Do the arguments comport with your experience and/or intuition? What are the main weaknesses in the author's argument?

Proposal for the research paper (10%)

By Week 6 of the course (due Sunday at midnight), you will put together a research proposal (2-3 pages, about 1000 words) research proposal. The aim of the proposal is to focus your research question and develop a strategy for the rest of your research. Your proposal should include the following elements:

- a. Statement of your research question.

- b. Brief discussion of ideas or theories from academic literature that might help you to organize an answer to your research question; i.e., an annotated bibliography. At least 70% of the works you pick should be from the following journals: *APSR*, *AJPS*, *IO*, *JOP*, *JCR*, *JPR*, *ISQ*, *CMPS*, *Int. Peacekeeping*, and *Ter. and Pol. Violence*. Two of the works you pick should be either the theoretical or case study chapter of a university press book.
- c. Brief discussion of the empirical evidence that you have uncovered so far, if any.
- d. Plan for completing the research – what information you need to answer your question well, and how / where you plan to look for that information.
- e. Short formal bibliography (about 4-6 sources, not including assigned reading for the course) of the works you have consulted in designing your project.
- f. Conceptual map of the concept you have picked.
- g. Causal graph of your concept, either as the outcome or causal variable.

Final paper (30%)

In order to develop a feasible and interesting research paper, you must first devise an explicit research question that you plan to address.

Whatever area of focus, the task of your research question is to ask how or why something in that area of focus happens. The task of your research project is to develop an answer to this question that draws on theory that we have looked at in the course (or can be reasonably connected to theory we have examined in the course), and provides empirical evidence from one or more cases.

You can draw on both scholarly and non-scholarly sources as necessary. You should use 12 point font, double space your text, and use a consistent and established citation style. The final project should be around 16 pages (double spaced) in length (about 4,000 words), not including references, and will be submitted on the Canvas system, as well as Turnitin.com. The penalty for late submission of this project is 10% per day, including weekend days.

You should start with picking a concept that is used in political science. It could be very abstract (e.g., war, peace), very concrete (e.g., disarmament, demobilization, and reintegration), or something in between (e.g., state fragility, post-conflict commitment problems). Construct a narrative of your concept's history and etymological roots. How has this word been used over time in ordinary language, scholarly texts, and political documents? What are the effects of how this concept has been wielded? Diagram the concept's dimensions, specify the measures, and discuss the intension/extension. What is it about the concept and/or its operationalization that makes it work well? How has it been measured? Draw the causal graph of the concept. Identify antecedent, causal, mediating, outcome factors/variables. If different authors present various causal mechanisms, draw them all to present differences in argumentation. You can use www.visme.co to draw diagrams.

Students are encouraged to submit work to the Journal of Political Studies (JPS) and the Journal of International Affairs (JIA). The JPS and JIA are entirely student-led, blind peer-reviewed journals that publish undergraduate work. Both journals publish all types of papers from multiple disciplines. Visit ubcjps.com and ubcjia.ca for submission requirements. When in doubt, submit your work.

5-Minute presentation of final paper (10%):

Students will deliver a 5-minute presentation summarizing their final project on the last class and take critical questions from the audience.

Students will be evaluated on their ability to distill their core insights into the short time frame in an engaging and thoughtful manner. Students will also be evaluated for the sophistication and credibility of their responses to critical questions from the audience.

Use of Generative AI

If you make use of generative artificial intelligence tools, such as ChatGPT, to complete any project deliverables or other course-related work, the generated material must be clearly and correctly indicated, and cited/referenced. Failure to clearly indicate and reference AI-generated material will be reported as academic misconduct.

Late Submission Policy

Late assignments will be penalized 3% per 24-hour period beginning with the start of class on the due date. To be considered for extensions for papers, make-up exams, and/or being excused for an absence, Arts Students must contact [Arts Advising](#) (Buchanan D111) as soon as you are aware you may need an [in-term concession](#). Please review [their website](#) for concession criteria as well as process to follow. Students in other Faculties should contact their Faculty advising office for direction.

Lecture Outline and Readings:

Week 1 – Introduction to the Syllabus [September 3]

Week 2 – No class: Instructor attending APSA conference [September 10]

Week 3 – State Fragility: Conceptualization and Operationalization [September 17]

- Carr, Deborah, et al. 2018. *The Art and Science of Social Research*. New York, NY: W. W. Norton & Company. [Pages 101-119]
- Ferreira, Ines A. 2017. "Measuring State Fragility: A Review of the Theoretical Groundings of Existing Approaches." *Third World Quarterly* 38(6): 1291-1309.
- Beenhner, Lionel, and Joseph Young. 2014. "Is Ranking Failed or Fragile State a Futile Business?" *The Washington Post* (14 July).
- Watch "[How the US Failed to Rebuild Afghanistan](#)." [6 mins]

Week 4 – A Well-Functioning State [September 24]

- Gerring, John. 2012. *Social Science Methodology: A Unified Framework*. New York, NY: Cambridge University Press. [Pages 112 to 138]
- DeRouen, Karl, and Shaun Goldfinch. 2012. "What Makes a State Stable and Peaceful? Good Governance, Legitimacy and Legal-Rationality Matter Even More for Low-Income Countries." *Civil Wars* 14(4): 499-520.

- Schwartz, Stephanie. 2015. "Are Elections Straining Burundi's Fragile Peace?" *The Washington Post* (27 March).
- Watch "[Divided Island: How Haiti and the DR Became Two Worlds](#)." [15 mins]

Week 5 – Civil War Recurrence: Causes and Mechanisms [October 1]

- Gerring, John. 2012. *Social Science Methodology: A Unified Framework*. New York, NY: Cambridge University Press. [Pages 223-243]
- Walter, Barbara F. 2015. "Why Bad Governance Leads to Repeat Civil War." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 59(7): 1242-1272.
- Roessler, Philip. 2013. "Why South Sudan has Exploded in Violence." *The Washington Post* (24 December).
- Watch "[Inside the Forgotten War in Darfur, Where the Killing Never Stopped](#)." [14 mins]

Week 6 – Preventing Civil War Recurrence [October 8]

- Mross, Karina, Charlotte Fiedler, and Jörn Grävingholt. 2022. "Identifying Pathways to Peace: How International Support Can Help Prevent Conflict Recurrence." *International Studies Quarterly* 66(1): 1-14.
- Sharif, Sally, and Madhav Joshi. 2023. "Territorial Consolidation After Rebel Victory: When does Civil War Recur?" *Territory, Politics, Governance* (August).
- Firchow, Palmina. 2019. "Colombia's Long-Term Peace may Depend on Support for the Truth Commission." *The Washington Post* (4 February).
- Watch "[Why are there Protests against UN Peacekeepers in DR Congo](#)." [24 mins]

Week 7 – Challenges and Puzzles of Intervention [October 15]

- Lake, David A. 2016. *The Statebuilder's Dilemma: On the Limits of Foreign Intervention*. Cornell University Press, 2016. [Chapters 1-2].
- Barma, Naazneen H. 2016. "Rethinking the Peacebuilding Puzzle." In *The Peacebuilding Puzzle Political Order in Post-Conflict States*. Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press.
- Mukhopadhyay, Dipali. 2014. "Lessons from Afghanistan: Warlord Politics aren't Always Bad for Democracy." *The Washington Post* (13 May).
- Watch "[France's War on Terror in Mali](#)." [15 mins]

Week 8 – Disarmament and Demobilization [October 22]

- Humphreys, Macartan, and Jeremy M. Weinstein. 2007. "Demobilization and Reintegration." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 51(4): 531-67.
- Schulhofer-Wohl, Jonah, and Nicholas Sambanis. 2010. "Disarmament, Demobilization, and Reintegration Program and Civil War Recurrence: An Assessment." *Research Report*. Sandoevenken: Folke Bernadotte Academy.
- Sharif, Sally. 2022. "Ethiopia's peace may Depend on Post-Conflict Plans for Tigray Soldiers." *The Washington Post* (18 November).
- Listen to "Francy Carranza-Franco, Demobilisation and Reintegration in Colombia" in the New Books for Political Science Podcast (24 April 2023).

Week 9 – Reintegration of Ex-Combatants [October 29]

- Walter, Barbara F. 2002. *Committing to Peace*. Princeton: Princeton University Press. [Chapter 2 and all the tables in Chapters 3-4]
- Spear, Joanna. 1999. “The Disarmament and Demobilisation of Warring Factions in the Aftermath of Civil Wars: Key Implementation Issues.” *Civil Wars* 2(2): 1-22.
- Cajak, Ledio. 2015. “The Complex Story of a Child Soldier.” *The Washington Post* (12 January).
- Watch “[Why Colombia’s Peace Deal is Failing](#).” [10 mins]

Week 10 – Security Sector Reform (SSR) [November 5]

- Berg, Louis-Alexandre. 2022. *Governing Security After War: The Politics of Institutional Change in the Security Sector*. Oxford, UK: Oxford University Press. [chapter 2]
- Lake, Milli. 2022. “Policing Insecurity.” *American Political Science Review* 116(3): 858–74.
- Wilén, Nina. 2015. “How to Unite Enemy Fighters into a Single National Army.” *The Washington Post* (11 November).
- Watch “Challenges of Security Sector Reform (SSR) in Afghanistan.” <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NTWI2KZ3-6k>. [5 mins]
- Watch “Inside the Afghan National Army.” https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Tlja_ZhNXdw. [43 mins]

Week 11 – Midterm Break [12 November]

- No class: UBC midterm break

Week 12 – Peace Agreement Implementation [November 19]

- Mattes, Michaela, and Burcu Savun. 2009. “Fostering Peace After Civil War: Commitment Problems and Agreement Design.” *International Studies Quarterly* 53: 737-759.
- Joshi, Madhav, and Jason M. Quinn. 2017. “Implementing the Peace: The Aggregate Implementation of Comprehensive Peace Agreements and Peace Duration after Intrastate Armed Conflict.” *British Journal of Political Science* 47(4): 869–892.
- Camara, Kamissa. 2016. “Violent protests have erupted in Mali: Here is What is Driving them.” *The Washington Post* (15 August).
- Listen to “[Ex-Combatants and Peace Agreement with the FARC-EP in Colombia](#).”

Week 13 – International Involvement in Peace Agreement Implementation [November 26]

- Maekawa, Wakako, Barış Arı, and Theodora-Ismene Gizelis. 2019. “UN Involvement and Civil War Peace Agreement Implementation.” *Public Choice* 178: 397–416.
- Karreth, Johannes, Jason Quinn, Madhav Joshi, and Jaroslav Tir. 2023. “International Third Parties and the Implementation of Comprehensive Peace Agreements After Civil War.” *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 67(2-3): 494-521.
- Campbell, Susana. 2015. “What Burundi's crisis says about U.N. capacity to build peace.” *The Washington Post* (18 May).

- Watch “[Patrolling the Lawless Sahara Desert with the Blue Helmets](#).” [12 mins]

Week 14 – Student presentations

Acknowledgement

UBC's Point Grey Campus is located on the traditional, ancestral, and unceded territory of the Musqueam people. The land it is situated on has always been a place of learning for the Musqueam people, who for millennia have passed on in their culture, history, and traditions from one generation to the next on this site.

General Academic Policies

Regular attendance in class meetings is expected. All assignments must be completed and handed in.

Read the university calendar so that you are aware of no-penalty drop dates, requirements for medical authorization (to defer an exam, for example) and other procedures that may affect you.

Students who wish to appeal grades assigned to their academic work may do so. The initial appeal should be made to the course instructor. If the student remains unsatisfied with this process, he/she may proceed to the head of the department or further to a formal committee established in accordance with University policies.

Religious holidays – UBC permits students who are scheduled to attend classes or write examinations on holy days of their religions to notify their instructor in advance of these days and their wish to observe them by absenting themselves from class or examination. Instructors provide opportunity for students to make up work or examinations missed without penalty. (Policy # 65.)

UBC is committed to the academic success of students with disabilities. UBC's policy on Academic Accommodations for students with disabilities aims to remove barriers and provide equal access to University services, ensure fair and consistent treatment of all students, and to create a welcoming environment. Students with a disability should first meet with an Access and Diversity advisor to determine what accommodations/services you are eligible for.

Academic Integrity and Responsibility

As a member of this class, you are responsible for contributing to the course objectives through your participation in class activities and your work on essays and other projects. In the process of coming into your own as an independent, responsible participant in the academic community, you are encouraged to seek advice, clarification, and guidance in your learning from your instructor. If you decide to seek help beyond the resources of this course, you are responsible for ensuring that this help does not lead you to submit others' work as your own. If an outside tutor or other person helps you, show this policy to your tutor or helper: make sure you both understand the limits of this person's permissible contribution. If you are uncertain, consult your instructor.

Academic communities depend on their members' honesty and integrity in representing the sources of reasoning, claims, and wordings that appear in their work. Like any other member of the academic community, you will be held responsible for the accurate representation of your sources: the means by which you produced the work you are submitting. If you are found to have misrepresented your sources and to have submitted others' work as your own, penalties may follow. Your case may be forwarded to the Head of the department, who may decide that you should receive zero for the assignment. The Head will report your case to the Dean's Office, where the report will remain on file. The Head may decide, in consultation with your instructor, that a greater penalty is called for, and will forward your case to the Dean's Office. After an interview in the Dean's Office, your case may be forwarded to the President's Advisory Committee on Academic Misconduct. Following a hearing in which you will be asked to account for your actions, the President may apply penalties including zero for the assignment; zero for the course; suspension from the university for a period ranging from 4 to 24 months; a notation on your permanent record. The penalty may be a combination of these.

Academic communities also depend on their members' living up to the commitments they make. By enrolling in this course, you make commitments to an academic community: you are responsible for meeting deadlines, and attending class and engaging in class activities. If you find that you cannot meet a deadline or cannot participate in a course activity, discuss your situation with your instructor before the deadline or before your absence.

Like any academic author submitting work for review and evaluation, you are guaranteeing that the work you submit for this course has not already been submitted for credit in another course. Your submitting work from another course, without your instructor's prior agreement, may result in penalties such as those applied to the misrepresentation of sources.

Use of Generative AI

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Failure to clearly indicate and reference AI-generated material will be reported as academic misconduct.

COVID-19 Safety

If you are sick, it is important that you stay home. Complete a self-assessment for COVID-19 symptoms here: <https://bc.thrive.health/covid19/en>.

If I (the instructor) am feeling ill: If I am unwell, I will not come to class. I will make every reasonable attempt to communicate plans for the class as soon as possible by email. If I am well enough to teach, but am taking precautions to avoid infecting others, we may hold the class online. If this happens, you will receive an email informing you how to join the class.

Reach out and ask for help if you need it

University students often encounter setbacks from time to time that can impact academic performance. If you run into difficulties and need assistance, I encourage you to contact me by email. I will do my best to support your success during the term. This includes identifying concerns I may have about your academic progress or wellbeing through Early Alert. With Early Alert, faculty members can connect you with advisors who offer student's support and assistance getting back on track to success. Only specialized UBC advisors are able to access any concerns I may identify, and Early Alert does not affect your academic record.

For more information: <https://facultystaff.students.ubc.ca/systems-tools/early-alert>

For information about addressing mental or physical health concerns, including seeing a UBC counselor or doctor, visit: <https://students.ubc.ca/health-wellness>

Respectful University Environment

UBC recognizes that “the best possible environment for working, learning and living is one in which respect, civility, diversity, opportunity and inclusion are valued.” The full *UBC Statement on Respectful Environment for Students, Faculty and Staff* can be found at <http://www.hr.ubc.ca/respectful-environment/files/UBC-Statement-on-Respectful-Environment-2014.pdf>. Students should read this statement carefully and take note of both the protections and the responsibilities that it outlines for all members of the UBC community. Students should also review the Student Code of Conduct, at: <http://www.calendar.ubc.ca/vancouver/index.cfm?tree=3,54,750,0>

This course values frank discussion, healthy debate, and the free and respectful exchange of ideas. Students are welcome to voice and defend their views, which may differ from those of other students or of the instructor. However, disrespectful behavior, including bullying and harassment, will not be tolerated. The instructor will be professional and respectful in all their exchanges with students, and students will exercise similar professionalism and respect in their interactions with each other and with the instructor.

I expect us all to respect the preferred personal pronouns of all students. Using the right pronoun, like using someone's correct name, is a way to show respect. Please advise me of your pronoun preference early in the semester so I can respond as appropriate.

If you have any concerns about the class environment, please raise them with the instructor. You also have the options of contacting the Head of the Political Science Department, UBC's Equity and Inclusion Office (<http://equity.ubc.ca>), or the UBC Ombudsperson for Students: <https://ombudsoffice.ubc.ca>

Equity and Harassment

UBC is committed to equity (including but not limited to gender equity) and fostering a safe learning environment for everyone. All peoples should be able to study, work, and learn in a supportive environment that is free from sexual violence, harassment, and discrimination. UBC's Policy #3 on Discrimination and Harassment defines harassment as: "unwanted and unwelcome attention from a person who knows, or ought to know, that the behaviour is unwelcome. Harassment can range from written or spoken comments to unwanted jokes, gifts, and physical assault, and may be accompanied by threats or promises regarding work or study opportunities and conditions. Harassment can be either a single incident or a series of related incidents." Such behavior is not acceptable and will not be tolerated at UBC. If you or someone you know has encountered sexual violence or harassment, you can find confidential support and resources at the AMS Sexual Assault Support Centre, (SASC), and the Equity and Inclusion Office. The SASC is an all-genders service that serves the UBC-Vancouver campus community and is committed to creating a safer campus community, free from sexualized violence. Their work is informed by feminism, anti-oppression and recognition of intersectionality. The Equity and Inclusion Office is committed to fostering a community in which human rights are respected and equity and diversity are integral to university life.

Resources are available at:

Sexual Assault Support Centre, (SASC)

249M, Student Union Building, UBC

604-827-5180

sasc@ams.ubc.ca

<http://amssasc.ca>

Equity and Inclusion Office

2306 – 1874 East Mall (Brock Hall)

604.822.6353

equity@equity.ubc.ca

<http://equity.ubc.ca>